

# Robots May Not Take Your Job. But What Else Might They Take?

*Venny Kojouharov*

For years, one question has dominated conversations about the future of robotics. Will robots take our jobs? But imagine, for a moment, that they don't. Imagine instead that robots take our laundry.

Robotics companies are increasingly building general-purpose machines intended to operate in our homes and workplaces. Their demonstrations of robots folding clothes, loading dishwashers, cleaning kitchens, and preparing food are easy to appreciate. As a roboticist, I find this future exciting, and I would happily hand over a basket of dirty laundry and never think about it again.

But laundry is not technologically special. A robot capable of reliably sorting and folding arbitrary clothes in the chaos of a real home will likely be capable of much more. It could wash our dishes, clean our floors, cook our meals, unpack our groceries, tend our gardens, walk our dogs, and handle basic household maintenance. Each sounds like a small improvement to our lives. Together, they raise a harder question. **When we automate the mundane parts of life, what else might we inadvertently automate away?**

This question is not new. I was first introduced to it through Albert Borgmann, a philosopher who wrote about an older technology, central heating. Borgmann contrasted the furnace with the traditional fireplace it replaced. Keeping a fire going required cutting and carrying wood, tending the flames, and dividing responsibilities among family members. The work was inconvenient, but woven into it were physical activity, learned skills, time outdoors, family cooperation, and a daily connection to the changing seasons. The thermostat preserved the thing we initially

wanted, warmth, while quietly removing much of the activity that surrounded it.

Borgmann's point was not that we should abandon central heating and return to chopping wood. It was that technologies designed to remove work can also remove experiences, relationships, and practices that happened to be embedded in that work.

That idea may be even more pertinent today. Until now, much of household automation has happened one task at a time. The washing machine automated washing clothes. The dishwasher automated dishes. The thermostat automated heating. The robotic vacuum automated cleaning floors. General-purpose robots could be different. Rather than designing a machine for one chore, we are trying to create machines that can effectively *do whatever physical task we don't feel like doing*.

The problem is that a robot has no inherent way to distinguish drudgery from meaningful effort.

Cooking dinner can be an exhausting obligation after a long day, or an hour spent with your family. Gardening can mean tedious yard maintenance, or someone's favorite Saturday morning. Walking the dog can be an inconvenience in the rain, or the reason you spend an hour outside every day and know the people who live on your block.

The same task can be both a chore and a meaningful part of life.

Now, consider something as ordinary as realizing you need tomatoes for dinner. Today, you might walk to a grocery store or farmers market, see other people, choose your food, perhaps stop somewhere else on the way home, cook dinner, and clean up afterward.

Alternatively, a sufficiently capable system could eliminate almost all of that friction. An AI notices you are running low on tomatoes and orders them. An autonomous vehicle delivers them. A household robot puts them away, prepares dinner, and cleans the kitchen afterward.

It is difficult to argue against the convenience. But there is one striking difference between the two scenarios: **you never left your house.**

On any given evening, that hardly seems consequential. But, multiply the same transformation across millions of households and hundreds of everyday activities, and the consequences become harder to dismiss.

Grocery stores, farmers markets, cafés, restaurants, neighborhood shops, sidewalks, and downtowns are not sustained only because humans have an intrinsic desire to gather in them. Many are sustained because we need food, goods, services, exercise, and other things that require us to physically participate in the world. Along the way, those necessities create interactions we rarely plan: seeing a neighbor at the market, talking to the person behind a counter, walking through a neighborhood, or simply spending time around strangers.

General-purpose robots would not intentionally eliminate any of these things. They could simply eliminate many of the reasons we encounter them.

This is why the question is larger than whether robots will make people lazy. Routine responsibilities form part of a hidden infrastructure connecting us to our families, communities, local economies, and physical environment. We rarely notice that infrastructure because it is intertwined with inconvenience.

We have seen a version of this problem before. Digital technologies transformed how we communicate, consume information, shop, and entertain ourselves long before institutions understood their broader consequences. Today, policymakers are still grappling with how social media and artificial intelligence affect education, employment, privacy, misinformation, and social connection.

Physical AI could present an even broader challenge because its effects will not end at the screen. Digital technologies have changed how we

interact with the world. Increasingly capable robots could remove the need for some of those interactions altogether.

That does not mean policymakers should decide who is allowed to use a robot to wash the dishes. Nor should we romanticize unnecessary hardship. Robots can remove dangerous, exhausting, and genuinely miserable work from people's lives. That is something worth pursuing.

But policy surrounding robotics cannot focus exclusively on safety, liability, and job displacement. As physical AI becomes more capable, questions about urban planning, public space, local businesses, physical activity, and social connection may become robotics questions too. If technology dramatically reduces the necessity of participating in public life, we should be thinking about how to build communities in which people still *choose* to participate.

Roboticians should ask similar questions. We often measure progress by autonomy, tasks completed without human involvement. Human effort is implicitly treated as a cost to minimize, but often, human participation is part of the value. The best robot is not always the one that removes us entirely. Perhaps a robot might cook *with* us rather than for us, help us garden rather than garden for us, or make physical activity easier without making our participation unnecessary.

I still want a robot to do my laundry. But as robots become capable of doing more of everyday life, we should be careful not to assume that everything inconvenient is therefore without value.

Soon, the important question may no longer be simply **what can robots do for us?**

It may be **what do we still want to do ourselves?**